

United Front in 1954

Historical Context and formation of the United Front

After the creation of Pakistan in 1947, East Bengal faced political, cultural, and economic discrimination from the West Pakistan-dominated central government. The **Muslim League**, which ruled East Bengal, failed to reflect the hopes and needs of the Bengali population.

The key background factors behind the formation of the United Front were:

1. **Language Movement (1948–1952):** The refusal to recognize *Bengali as a state language* deeply hurt national identity and united Bengalis against the central government.
2. **Muslim League's Failure in Governance:** People became unhappy due to corruption, mismanagement, rising prices, and failure to deliver development.
3. **Growing Demand for Regional Autonomy:** Bengalis wanted more political power, economic fairness, and protection of cultural identity.

Before the 1954 election, the **Muslim League** was the most influential party and controlled the East Bengal government. To defeat them, four opposition parties formed a coalition called the **United Front** on 14 November 1953 in Mymensingh.

The coalition included four parties:

1. **Awami Muslim League** – led by Maulana Abdul Hamid Khan Bhashani
2. **Krishak-Praja Party** – led by A.K. Fazlul Haque
3. **Nezam-e-Islami** – led by Maulana Atahar Ali
4. **Left Democratic Party** – led by Haji Mohammad Danesh

Here, the election symbol of the United Front was the **Boat**.

They announced a **21-point election manifesto**, written mainly by **Abul Mansur Ahmed** based on the demands of the people of East Bengal.

Major Points of the United Front Election Manifesto (21-Point Charter) are given below:

The United Front's manifesto highlighted political, economic, cultural, and social reforms. The most important demands included:

- Bengali to be recognized as a state language of Pakistan
- Abolition of the Zamindari system and land to be given to landless farmers
- Nationalization of the jute industry and promotion of co-operative farming
- Free and compulsory primary education in the mother tongue
- Steps to stop corruption, bribery, and nepotism
- Separation of the judiciary from the administration

- Recognition of the Language Movement martyrs and declaring 21 February as a public holiday
- Full autonomy for East Bengal according to the Lahore Resolution

These promises connected directly with people's daily struggles, making the manifesto popular and acceptable to almost all classes of society.

Election Results and Government Formation (1954)

The United Front won a big victory in the 1954 election. They won **223 out of 237 Muslim seats**, while the Muslim League got only **10 seats**, showing that most people supported the United Front. They also won **13 out of 72 non-Muslim seats**. After the victory, the United Front formed the government on **3 April 1954** with **A.K. Fazlul Haque** as the Chief Minister. Later, on **15 May 1954**, the Awami League joined the cabinet and **Sheikh Mujibur Rahman** became the **Minister of Agriculture, Cooperatives, and Rural Development**.

Key Factors Behind the United Front's Success in the 1954 Election

- **Support after the Language Movement:** People supported the United Front because it promised to give respect to the Bengali language and culture.
- **Unity of Opposition Parties:** Different opposition parties joined together, which made them stronger than the Muslim League.
- **Popular and Trusted Leaders:** Leaders like A.K. Fazlul Haque, Maulana Bhashani, and Sheikh Mujibur Rahman were close to the people and had strong public support.
- **Decline of the Muslim League:** The Muslim League became unpopular due to corruption, poor leadership, and not listening to the public.
- **Unfair Treatment of East Bengal:** People were unhappy because West Pakistan got more benefits and East Bengal was neglected.
- **People-Friendly 21-Point Manifesto:** The United Front offered solutions for farmers, workers, students, and the poor, which made their promises attractive and realistic.

Conclusion

The formation of the United Front was a historic response to cultural injustice, political discrimination, and economic inequality faced by East Bengal. By uniting major political forces, the United Front offered a strong alternative to the Muslim League. Their success in the 1954 election came from public trust, effective leadership, and a people-centered manifesto that reflected the aspirations of the Bengali population.

Six-Point Movement

Introduction

The Six-Point Movement was a political movement in East Pakistan led by **Sheikh Mujibur Rahman** in 1966. It demanded greater autonomy and rights for East Pakistan. It is known as the “**Charter of Freedom**” because it played a major role in the struggle for the independence of Bangladesh. The **six point demands** are:

1. **Give more power to provinces:**
Pakistan should be a federation where provinces have the main power.
2. **Central powers limited:**
The central government should control only **defence and foreign affairs**.
3. **Separate currency or financial system:**
East Pakistan should have its own currency or full control of its money to stop economic exploitation.
4. **Provincial control of taxes:**
Provinces should collect and use their own taxes and revenue.
5. **Control over trade and business:**
Provinces should manage their own trade and foreign exchange earnings.
6. **Separate security force for East Pakistan:**
East Pakistan should have its own militia or paramilitary force for security.

Reasons behind the Six-Point Movement

East Pakistan faced discrimination in almost every sector. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman announced the Six-Point demand to end this inequality. The main reasons were:

- **Cultural Discrimination:** West Pakistan tried to impose Urdu as the only state language and looked down on Bengali culture.
- **Economic Exploitation:** East Pakistan received less budget, fewer development projects, and had no control over its earnings.
- **Administrative Inequality:** Very few Bengalis had high government jobs. Most top posts were taken by West Pakistanis.
- **Lack of Political Rights:** East Pakistan was denied provincial autonomy. Martial law in 1958 took away democratic rights.
- **Military Neglect:** Bengalis had very little representation in the army, and East Pakistan was left unprotected during the 1965 Indo-Pak war.

Because of these injustices, Sheikh Mujib presented the Six Points at a conference in Lahore on **5–6 February 1966**.

Importance of the Six-Point Demands in the Independence Movement of Bangladesh

The Six-Point Demands became the **main foundation of Bengali nationalism** and played a key role in leading the country toward independence.

1. Turned the Autonomy Demand into a Mass Movement

The Six Points gave the people a clear idea of what rights they needed. It united students, workers, and common people across East Pakistan to demand autonomy.

2. Showed the Unfairness of the Pakistani Government

West Pakistan rejected the Six Points and tried to suppress the movement through arrests, cases (like the Agartala Conspiracy Case), and violence. This made Bengalis realize that justice could not be achieved under Pakistan's rule.

3. Built Strong Bengali National Identity

The movement made Bengalis more aware that they were a separate nation with their own language, culture, economy, and needs. The idea of ruling themselves became stronger among the people.

4. Made Sheikh Mujibur Rahman the Leader of Bengalis

The Six Points established Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as the main leader of the Bengali people. He became the symbol of their struggle for rights and autonomy, and the nation began to see him as "Bangabandhu."

5. Led to the Huge Victory in the 1970 Election

Awami League won the 1970 election with the Six Points as their main agenda. But when West Pakistan refused to transfer power, it became clear that Bengalis needed full independence.

6. Paved the Way to the Liberation War

Since the Six Points were not accepted, the movement grew stronger, leading to mass protests and the non-cooperation movement in 1971. Finally, this struggle turned into the Liberation War and resulted in independence.

Conclusion

The Six-Point Demands of 1966 were rooted in political discrimination, economic inequality, and the failure to secure provincial rights under Pakistan. They gave a clear vision of self-autonomy, awakened national consciousness, united the Bengali people, and paved the way toward full independence.

Mass Upsurge of 1969

The Mass Upsurge of 1969 was a turning point in the political history of East Pakistan. It began with student protests against the authoritarian rule of President Ayub Khan and soon became a mass movement demanding democracy, rights, and an end to discrimination against Bengalis. The movement played a crucial role in shaping the path toward Bangladesh's independence.

Causes of the Mass Upsurge

Several factors led to the movement:

1. **Authoritarian Rule of Ayub Khan:** Martial Law in 1958 ended democracy and political rights. People became frustrated with military dictatorship.
2. **Economic Exploitation:** Development was centered in West Pakistan, while East Pakistan remained neglected in budget, industry, and infrastructure.
3. **Administrative and Political Discrimination:** Bengalis were deprived of government jobs, political power, and fair representation. The government ignored East Pakistan's demands, including the Six-Point Movement.
4. **Agartala Conspiracy Case (1968):** Sheikh Mujibur Rahman and others were falsely accused of treason. Their arrest united the people, who demanded their release.

Trend and nature of the Mass Upsurge

1. **Started with Students, Then Became a Public Movement:**
It began with student protests but soon spread to workers, farmers, teachers, and common people across East Pakistan.
2. **Against Dictatorship, For Democracy:**
The movement demanded an end to Ayub Khan's military rule and called for democratic rights and freedom for the people.
3. **Student Leadership and the 11-Point Programme:**
Students led the movement by forming the **All-Party Student Struggle Council** on 4 January 1969. They supported the Six-Point demand and announced the **11-Point Programme**, which included:
 - Better education facilities and student welfare
 - Full democracy and direct elections
 - Full autonomy for East Pakistan
 - Nationalization of key industries
 - Rights of workers and farmers

The 11-Point Programme converted a student protest into a **mass movement**, as it reflected the demands of all groups: students, workers, farmers, and ordinary citizens.

4. People-Centered and Non-Communal:

People of all religions, classes, and professions joined together. It showed unity, public awareness, and a strong desire for justice and self-rule.

5. Continued Despite Pressure and Restrictions:

Even after government restrictions like curfews and arrests, people kept protesting. The loss of young protestors increased public support and gave the movement more strength.

6. Brought Major Political Change:

Public anger forced the government to withdraw the **Agartala Case**, and on 22 February 1969 Sheikh Mujib and others were released.

- On 23 February 1969, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was given the title “**Bangabandhu**”.
- Ayub Khan failed to control the situation and handed power to **General Yahya Khan** on 25 March 1969.

Significance of the 1969 Movement in the Emergence of Bangladesh

1. Strengthened Bengali Nationalism:

The movement united Bengalis and strengthened the demand for autonomy. It created a strong sense of identity and self-respect among East Pakistanis.

2. Recognition of Bangabandhu as the Leader of the Nation:

Sheikh Mujibur Rahman was freed on **22 February 1969** and was given the title “**Bangabandhu**”. This established him as the undisputed leader of the Bengalis.

3. Acceptance of the Six-Point Demand:

The movement increased public support for the Six-Point demand, which later became the main political basis for independence.

4. Collapse of Ayub Khan’s Regime:

The movement ended Ayub Khan’s 10-year rule and weakened West Pakistan’s control over East Pakistan.

5. Pathway to the 1970 Election:

Due to the uprising, elections were announced. In 1970, the Awami League won a landslide victory reflecting the people's choice for autonomy.

6. “Dress Rehearsal” of the Liberation War:

The movement prepared the people mentally, politically, and socially for the **1971 War of Independence**. It is often called a **pre-stage** of the Liberation War.

Conclusion

The Mass Upsurge of 1969 united the people of East Pakistan to fight for autonomy, democracy, and justice. It weakened Pakistan’s military rule, increased Bengali nationalism, and prepared the ground for the 1970 elections and the 1971 Liberation War. Therefore, the movement is regarded as a major step toward the independence of Bangladesh.

Election of 1970

Appreciate the Background of the Election of 1970 and Evaluate the Result of the Election and its Influence on the Independence War of 1971

Introduction

The General Election of 1970 was the first national election in Pakistan based on adult voting rights. It became a major turning point in the history of the subcontinent. This election clearly showed the political divide between East and West Pakistan and finally led to the independence of Bangladesh in 1971.

Background of the Election of 1970

1. **End of Ayub Khan's Rule and Demand for Democracy:**
Ayub Khan's military rule from 1958 to 1969 destroyed democracy. The Mass Upsurge of 1969 forced him to resign. Yahya Khan became President and promised free and fair elections, which raised public expectations.
2. **Popularity of the Six-Point Demand:**
Sheikh Mujibur Rahman's Six-Point Movement of 1966 demanded autonomy for East Pakistan. The Mass Upsurge of 1969 made the Six Points widely accepted, turning it into the main political agenda for East Pakistan.
3. **Deep Economic and Regional Disparity:**
East Pakistan faced continued economic exploitation, lower budget allocation, fewer development projects, and inequality in military and administrative sectors. This discrimination strengthened the demand for autonomy.
4. **Failure of West Pakistan to Ensure Political Rights:**
East Pakistan was denied proper political representation. Even after United Front's victory in 1954, power was not handed over. This history of injustice made 1970 election highly significant for East Pakistanis.
5. **Cyclone Disaster and Government Negligence (1970):**
The Bhola Cyclone caused massive deaths in East Pakistan. West Pakistan's slow relief efforts angered Bengalis and increased support for the Awami League.

Results of the 1970 Election

- The election was held in December 1970 for **300 National Assembly seats**.
- **Awami League won 167 out of 169 seats in East Pakistan**, securing absolute majority to form the central government.
- In West Pakistan, **Zulfikar Ali Bhutto's Pakistan People's Party (PPP)** won 81 seats.
- According to democratic rules, **Sheikh Mujibur Rahman should have become the Prime Minister of Pakistan**.

- However, the West Pakistani ruling elite and military refused to transfer power to the Awami League.

Influence on the Independence War of 1971

1. **Denial of Transfer of Power:**

Yahya Khan and Bhutto refused to let the Awami League form the government, even after winning the election. This proved that West Pakistan would never allow fair rights to Bengalis.

2. **Rise of Bengali Nationalism:**

Bengalis realized that democratic rights within Pakistan were impossible. The demand for autonomy now transformed into a demand for a separate state.

3. **Non-Cooperation Movement:**

On 7 March 1971, Bangabandhu delivered a historic speech calling for non-cooperation against Pakistan's rule. This united the entire nation and prepared the people mentally for independence.

4. **Military Crackdown (Operation Searchlight):**

On 25 March 1971, the Pakistani army launched a brutal attack on East Pakistan. This marked the beginning of the Liberation War.

5. **Election Proved the People's Mandate for Freedom:**

The 1970 election clearly showed that the people wanted the Awami League to lead. When this legal right was denied, independence became the only path.

Conclusion

The 1970 election clearly reflected the will of the people of East Pakistan to establish autonomy and end discrimination. The refusal of the West Pakistani rulers to hand over power made independence inevitable. Therefore, the election of 1970 is considered the **final political step** that led directly to the **Liberation War of 1971** and the birth of Bangladesh.

Sector-Based Battle

Review of the Spontaneous Resistance and Sector-Based Strategic Battle During the Nine-Month Liberation War of Bangladesh

Introduction

The Liberation War of 1971 was a nine-month-long struggle in which the people of Bangladesh fought against the Pakistani military to achieve independence. The war succeeded due to two key elements: the **spontaneous resistance of the people** and a well-organized **sector-based military strategy** led by the Mukti Bahini.

Spontaneous Resistance During the Liberation War

1. **Immediate Public Uprising After 25 March 1971:**
After the Pakistani Army launched *Operation Searchlight*, people across East Pakistan began resisting with courage. Civilians, students, villagers, government employees, and even common citizens joined the fight.
2. **Mass Participation From All Walks of Life:**
Farmers, workers, teachers, cultural activists, police, and EPR soldiers participated in protests, guerrilla attacks, and disrupted enemy communication lines.
3. **Formation of Mukti Bahini:**
Bengali members of the army, police, Ansar, EPR, and volunteers came together to form the **Mukti Bahini** (Liberation Forces). Youths crossed the border for training and returned to fight.
4. **Guerrilla Warfare in Early Stages:**
People used small arms, homemade weapons, and surprise attacks to destroy enemy camps, bridges, rail lines, and supply routes, making it difficult for the Pakistani army to control the region.
5. **Cultural and Moral Resistance:**
Swadhin Bangla Betar Kendra inspired fighters and the public through patriotic songs, poems, speeches, and news updates, keeping the spirit of freedom alive.
6. **Support From Local Communities:**
Villagers sheltered freedom fighters, shared food, gave information, and protected them. Local cooperation made resistance stronger and more effective.
7. **Student and Youth Leadership:**
Students played a major role in organizing early resistance groups, spreading messages, motivating people, and joining the Mukti Bahini.
8. **Role of Women in Resistance:**
Women worked as nurses, messengers, informants, and helped freedom fighters with food, shelter, and information. Many also trained and joined resistance forces.
9. **International Awareness Efforts:**
Bengalis living abroad, students, and diplomats created awareness, organized rallies, and requested world support for Bangladesh's cause. This helped gain sympathy from other countries.

10. Use of Local Knowledge and Terrain:

Freedom fighters used knowledge of rivers, forests, and villages to plan resistance activities, making it challenging for the Pakistani forces to operate effectively.

Sector-Based Strategic Battle of the Liberation War

To conduct an organized war, Bangladesh was divided into **11 military sectors** led by experienced commanders under the leadership of **Colonel M.A.G. Osmani (Commander-in-Chief of Mukti Bahini)**.

Sector	Commander(s)	Headquarters / Area
1	Major Ziaur Rahman	Chattogram & Hill Tracts
2	Major Khaled Mosharraf	Dhaka - Mymensingh
3	Major K.M. Shafiullah	Comilla
4	Major C.R. Dutta	Sylhet
5	Major Mir Shawkat Ali	Rangpur
6	Wing Cmdr. M. Khademul Bashar	Rajshahi
7	Major Nazmul Huq → Major Quazi Nuruzzaman	Rajshahi-Kushtia-Jessore
8	Major Abul Manzur	Kushtia-Jessore-Khulna
9	Major M.A. Jalil	Barishal-Patuakhali-Bhola
10	Captain M.N. Samad (Naval)	Naval Command
11	Major Abu Taher	Mymensingh-Tangail

War of Liberation (1971)

Introduction

The War of Liberation of Bangladesh began on **26 March 1971** and ended with the victory and independence of Bangladesh on **16 December 1971**. The war was the result of long-term political, economic, cultural, and administrative discrimination against East Pakistan by West Pakistan since 1947. Major issues such as the language movement, demand for autonomy, unequal development and refusal to transfer power gradually created the conditions that led to the war.

Background and Beginning of the War

In the general election of 1970, the **Awami League won 167 out of 169 seats** in East Pakistan, gaining the majority in the Pakistan National Assembly. Despite this clear mandate, the Pakistani military and ruling elites refused to hand over power. In protest, a massive civil disobedience movement began under the leadership of Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.

On the night of **25 March 1971**, the Pakistan Army started a brutal military operation named **“Operation Searchlight”** to suppress the Bengalis. Major General Tikka Khan became in-charge of the overall operation. Mass killing in Dhaka and other major cities triggered spontaneous resistance from the people. On **26 March 1971**, the declaration of independence inspired nationwide uprisings.

Formation of the Mujibnagar Government

Due to strong Pakistani military attacks, many freedom fighters temporarily moved to India to reorganize. On **10 April 1971**, the **Government of the People’s Republic of Bangladesh**, known as the **Mujibnagar Government**, was formed in Meherpur. It coordinated the Liberation War and gained international support.

Organization of Liberation Forces

Along with the **Mukti Bahini**, several local forces fought bravely in different regions, such as:

- Kader Bahini (Tangail)
- Latif Mirza Bahini (Sirajganj)
- Akbar Hossain Bahini (Jhenaidah)
- Hemayet Bahini (Faridpur)
- Quddus Molla & Gafur Bahini (Barishal)
- Afsar and Aftab Bahini (Mymensingh)

Inside Dhaka, the **Crack Platoon** carried out daring guerrilla missions, targeting key Pakistani installations to weaken enemy control.

Regular and Guerrilla Forces

Two types of forces fought in the war:

1. Guerrilla Forces:

Small groups entered Bangladesh to conduct hit-and-run attacks, sabotage communication lines, destroy bridges, and weaken the enemy through surprise operations.

2. Regular Forces (Bangladesh Forces):

Three regular brigades were formed to conduct conventional warfare:

- **Z Force (July 1971)** – led by **Major Ziaur Rahman**
- **S Force (October 1971)** – led by **Major Shafiullah**
- **K Force (late 1971)** – led by **Major Khaled Mosharraf**

The **Bangladesh Air Force** was formed on 28 September 1971 with a few aircraft under the command of **Air Commodore A.K. Khondaker**. The Bangladesh Navy began operations with a small fleet named “**Bangabandhu Naubahar**” from 9 November 1971.

International Support

The USA and China supported Pakistan or treated the crisis as Pakistan’s internal issue. However, India, the Soviet Union, and many global citizens supported Bangladesh. The **Indo-Soviet Friendship Treaty (9 August 1971)** strengthened India’s position against the US-China-Pakistan axis and helped Bangladesh strategically.

Joint Command and Victory

On **3 December 1971**, after Pakistan attacked Indian airbases, India officially joined the war, forming a **joint command** with the Mukti Bahini. Pakistani forces became weak and surrounded.

On **16 December 1971**, Pakistan surrendered at the **Ramna Racecourse (Suhrawardy Udyan)**. **Lt. General A.A.K. Niazi** signed the Instrument of Surrender in front of **Lt. General Jagjit Singh Aurora** of the Joint Command, marking the birth of independent Bangladesh.

Conclusion

The War of Liberation was the result of long years of injustice, discrimination, and denial of democratic rights. Through nine months of heroic struggle and sacrifices, the people of Bangladesh achieved independence. The unity of the nation, the armed resistance of the Mukti Bahini, and international support—especially from India—played a key role in this historic victory on **16 December 1971**.

Discrimination towards East Pakistan (1947–1971)

Introduction

From the creation of Pakistan in 1947 to 1971, East Pakistan (present-day Bangladesh) suffered continuous political, economic, cultural, military, and administrative discrimination from West Pakistan. Although East Pakistan had the majority of the population, power and national resources were controlled by the West Pakistani ruling elites. This long period of injustice ultimately led to the Liberation War of 1971.

1. Political Discrimination

- West Pakistan controlled political power and decision-making.
- Even though East Pakistan had a larger population, it was not given proportional representation in the National Assembly.
- The **United Front's victory in 1954** was not accepted; the East Pakistan government was dismissed soon after.
- **Martial Law of 1958** stopped democratic rights and restricted East Pakistani political leaders.
- The **Awami League's victory in the 1970 election** was rejected, and power was not handed over.

2. Cultural and Linguistic Discrimination

- Urdu was declared as the only state language of Pakistan, ignoring that most people spoke **Bangla**.
- Bengali culture, literature, and music were treated as “inferior” or “anti-Islamic”.
- Rabindranath Tagore's songs were banned on radio for years.
- The Language Movement of **1952** developed as a protest against this cultural suppression.

3. Economic Discrimination

- East Pakistan earned most of Pakistan's foreign currency through **jute exports**, but the money was spent mainly in West Pakistan.
- Development projects, industrial growth, and infrastructure were focused mostly in the western wing.
- Budget allocation was unfair – East received much less.
- The economic gap between the two wings widened every year, keeping East Pakistan economically weak.

4. Administrative Discrimination

- Government services and top positions were dominated by West Pakistanis.
- Very few Bengalis were appointed as senior officers in civil service, foreign service, or central government.

- Important government offices, including the capital, banks, and headquarters, were kept in West Pakistan, reducing opportunities for East Pakistanis.

5. Military Discrimination

- The Pakistan Army was mainly controlled by West Pakistanis.
- Very few Bengalis were recruited or promoted to higher military ranks.
- East Pakistan had almost **no military protection**; during the 1965 Indo-Pak war, the West Pakistani leaders said, “*The defense of East Pakistan lies in the West,*” proving their negligence.

6. Social and Regional Inequality

- Education, healthcare, transport, and communication facilities were better in West Pakistan.
- East Pakistan was treated as a colony rather than an equal partner of the nation.
- Natural disasters like the **1970 Bhola Cyclone** were ignored by the central government, which increased resentment.

Conclusion

Between 1947 and 1971, East Pakistan faced continuous discrimination in language, culture, politics, economy, military, and administration. The unfair treatment and denial of rights led to strong Bengali nationalism and demands for autonomy. These injustices ultimately resulted in the **Six-Point Movement**, the **Mass Upsurge of 1969**, and finally the **War of Liberation in 1971**, ending with the creation of Bangladesh.

Education Movement of 1962

Introduction

The Education Movement of 1962 was a major student-led protest in East Pakistan against the new education policy introduced by the Pakistan government. The movement played an important role in resisting discrimination in education and protecting the rights of Bengali students. It also strengthened student unity and contributed to later political movements that led to Bangladesh's independence.

Background / Causes of the Education Movement

In 1959, the Pakistan government formed an **Education Commission** headed by **Air Marshal Nur Khan** and later by **Dr. S.M. Sharif**. The Commission submitted a report in 1962, known as the **Sharif Education Commission Report**. The people of East Pakistan strongly opposed the policy for several reasons:

1. **Anti-People & Anti-Student Policy:**
The report suggested cuts in educational opportunities and aimed to limit higher education, which would harm students, especially in East Pakistan.
2. **Promoted Inequality:**
The policy favored rich and urban students but limited access to education for poor and rural students, increasing class inequality.
3. **Discouraged Mother-Tongue Based Education:**
It emphasized Urdu and English, weakening the importance of Bangla in education.
4. **Increased Education Costs:**
Tuition fees and expenses were to be increased, making education less affordable for common people.
5. **Aimed to Suppress Student Movements:**
The policy tried to reduce student involvement in politics and limit campus activities.

Course of the Movement

- Students began strong protests across East Pakistan demanding cancellation of the Education Commission Report.
- Student organizations formed an **All-Party Student Action Committee** to lead the movement.
- Rallies, strikes (hartals), and demonstrations were held in schools, colleges, and universities.
- Police were used to stop the protests, resulting in clashes in many places.

The movement reached its peak when police opened fire on protesting students in Dhaka and other cities, intensifying public anger.

Demands of the Students

The students raised several demands, including:

- Cancellation of the **Sharif Education Commission Report**
- Ensuring **free and fair access to education** for all
- Making education **affordable and equal** for all classes
- Ensuring **Bangla as a medium of instruction**
- Improving educational facilities and student rights

Outcome of the Education Movement

- The Pakistan government was forced to **withdraw the Sharif Commission Report**.
- The movement strengthened unity among students and developed political awareness.
- It proved that strong student movements could bring national change.
- The movement became a **stepping-stone for the Six-Point Movement (1966)** and the **Mass Upsurge of 1969**.

Conclusion

The Education Movement of 1962 was a powerful protest against discriminatory education policies in Pakistan. It established the students of East Pakistan as a major force for social and political change. The movement played an important role in protecting the rights of Bengali students and eventually contributed to the larger struggle for autonomy and independence.

Operation Searchlight and Mujibnagar Government

Introduction

Two key events at the start of the Liberation War of Bangladesh were **Operation Searchlight** and the formation of the **Mujibnagar Government**. Operation Searchlight showed the cruelty of the Pakistani army, while the Mujibnagar Government gave leadership, unity, and proper direction to the independence movement.

Operation Searchlight (25 March 1971)

Operation Searchlight was a planned military attack launched by the Pakistan Army on the night of **25 March 1971** to suppress the movement for autonomy in East Pakistan. The goal was to eliminate Bengali nationalism by force.

Objectives of Operation Searchlight:

- Crush the Awami League and stop the demand for autonomy
- Destroy student and political movements
- Arrest or kill nationalist leaders to break resistance

Events and Actions:

- The Pakistan Army attacked Dhaka University, student halls, Rajarbagh Police Lines, Pilkhana EPR Headquarters, media offices, and residential areas.
- Teachers, students, political activists, and unarmed civilians were shot, tortured, or arrested.
- Within days, the genocide spread across the country causing thousands of deaths.

Impact of Operation Searchlight:

- It sparked nationwide anger and united the Bengali people to fight for independence.
- On **26 March 1971**, the declaration of independence inspired spontaneous resistance throughout East Pakistan.
- Many Bengalis fled to India to reorganize and prepare for a full-scale war.

Mujibnagar Government (10 April 1971)

To lead the liberation struggle in an organized way, the first government of independent Bangladesh, called the **Mujibnagar Government**, was formed.

Formation and Swearing-in:

- Formed on **10 April 1971** and officially sworn in on **17 April 1971** at Baidyanathtala, Meherpur, later renamed **Mujibnagar**.

- Although **Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman** was declared the President, he was imprisoned in West Pakistan.

Leadership Structure:

- **President:** Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman (in absentia)
- **Acting President:** Syed Nazrul Islam
- **Prime Minister:** Tajuddin Ahmed
- **Commander-in-Chief of Liberation Forces:** Colonel M.A.G. Osmani

Role and Importance:

- The Mujibnagar Government officially declared Bangladesh an independent state and provided legitimacy to the liberation struggle.
- It directed all military operations of the **Mukti Bahini** and coordinated guerrilla and conventional warfare.
- It established foreign relations, gained international support, and boosted morale of freedom fighters.
- It united the people and gave a clear political structure and leadership to the war effort.

Conclusion

Operation Searchlight revealed that Pakistan wanted to silence Bengalis through genocide, proving that coexistence was impossible. In contrast, the Mujibnagar Government provided political, military, and diplomatic leadership for the war. Together, these two events marked the beginning of the Liberation War and laid the foundation for the victory and independence of Bangladesh on **16 December 1971**.

The Role of Superpowers During the Liberation War of Bangladesh (1971)

Introduction

The Liberation War of Bangladesh in 1971 was not only a regional conflict but also an important event during the Cold War. Big world powers like the **Soviet Union, United States, and China** became involved because of their political interests. Their actions affected the progress and result of the war.

Role of the Soviet Union (USSR)

- The Soviet Union strongly criticized Pakistan's military attack on the people of East Pakistan and asked Pakistan to solve the issue peacefully.
- USSR believed that using force against Bengalis would make the situation worse and could cause more problems in South Asia.
- To support India and balance the influence of the US and China, the **Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation** was signed on **9 August 1971**. This made India stronger diplomatically and militarily.
- The Soviet Union **used its veto power three times in the UN Security Council** to stop resolutions that supported Pakistan or called for an early ceasefire.
- By giving strong support to India and Bangladesh, the USSR played an important role in preventing outside military intervention and helped Bangladesh's independence movement.

Role of the United States (USA)

- The US government under President Richard Nixon supported Pakistan because Pakistan was helping the US build relations with China during the Cold War.
- The US did not openly condemn the genocide in East Pakistan, and continued to show political support for Pakistan.
- Although many American politicians and people protested and demanded that the US stop supporting Pakistan, the US government did not change its stand.
- The US sent relief for refugees but continued military and diplomatic support to Pakistan.
- In December 1971, the US sent the **Seventh Fleet** to the Bay of Bengal to pressure India and support Pakistan, but this did not change the outcome of the war.

Role of China

- China supported Pakistan from the beginning of the crisis and blamed India for interfering in Pakistan's internal matter.
- China provided **loans, weapons, and diplomatic support** to Pakistan.
- China wanted Pakistan to remain united because it considered Pakistan an important ally.
- However, China did **not send troops or directly join the war**, especially after India signed the treaty with the Soviet Union.

Role of the United Nations (UN)

- The United Nations discussed the Bangladesh crisis when the war started.
- The US pushed for a ceasefire, but the **Soviet Union used its veto** to block resolutions that did not mention the rights of the people of East Pakistan.
- Later, the UN General Assembly passed a resolution asking for a ceasefire and withdrawal of troops, but by that time Bangladesh was very close to victory.

Conclusion

During the Liberation War of 1971, superpowers acted mainly based on their own political interests. **China and the United States supported Pakistan**, while the **Soviet Union supported India and indirectly supported Bangladesh**. The USSR's vetoes and the Indo-Soviet Treaty helped prevent foreign interference, leading to Bangladesh's victory. Finally, Pakistan surrendered on **16 December 1971**, and Bangladesh became an independent country.